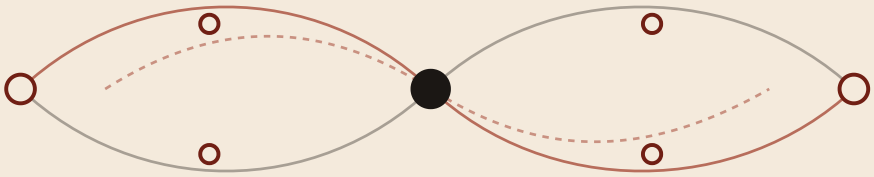
From Intention to Recoverable Continuity



1. From perception to intention

All work begins, at least in some form, with an idea about something that could be different. Someone observes something in their life or in the reality around them and perceives a possibility, a need, a problem, or a condition worth preserving. From that perception, an objective begins to take shape.

The objective does not appear in isolation. Perception is situated. People encounter reality through lenses influenced by their experience, knowledge, biological constitution, social position, and cultural context. These factors do not mechanically determine one conclusion, but they influence what becomes visible, which distinctions seem important, and which possibilities can be imagined.

At first, the objective often appears as a single monolithic intention: one large, still formless whole with little internal detail or clarity. A person may sense a direction before they can describe the destination precisely. They may know that something should change without yet knowing the work, constraints, or sequence required to change it. The intention carries a purpose, but its parts, relationships, and much of its meaning remain implicit.

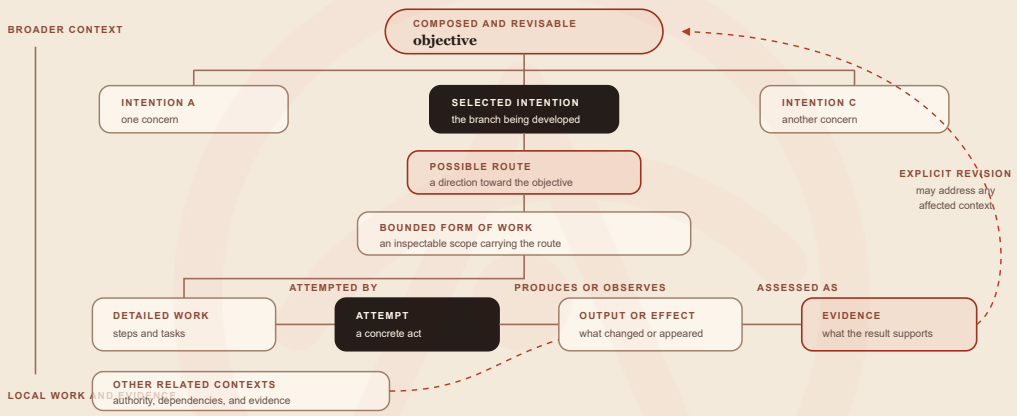
2. From a monolithic intention to a composition of intentions

In what follows, *context* has a narrower meaning than cultural context above. It is the recoverable set of relationships through which a piece of work remains connected to the purpose, constraints, decisions, evidence, and history that explain it.

As time and effort are invested, the monolithic intention begins to acquire contour. Distinctions appear inside it: outcomes, constraints, questions, and possible routes that were previously fused. Some of these distinctions become separate intentions, each with its own objective, scope, and possible work. Together, they compose the initial objective rather than merely sitting beneath it. The relationship is also recursive: what is learned while pursuing one of these intentions may clarify, challenge, or change the objective from which it emerged.

A *route* is a proposed direction toward the objective. A *bounded form of work* is the Plan, workstream, section, or directly bounded task that gives a selected route an inspectable scope. When a route needs its own proposal identity, authority search, and lifecycle, a Plan may carry it. Otherwise, a smaller form may be enough. Either can be decomposed into more detailed work without being mistaken for the attempts that later carry it out.

As an intention is differentiated, one context can lead to more local contexts without becoming their only explanation. Decomposition, execution, production, assessment, and revision remain distinct relationships.



Purpose remains traceable as selected context becomes local work. An attempt may produce an artifact or observed effect; assessment determines what that evidence supports. Any resulting revision is explicit and can address whichever context is affected.

A possible route may instead become one directly bounded task; the sequence above is an illustrative decomposition, not a required lifecycle.

The intention does not merely become longer. It becomes composed of more parts. What was once held together as one idea begins to appear across conversations, Plans, research, decisions, specifications, assignments, tasks, attempts, and changed files.

This makes focused work possible, but it changes what is visible. Attention moves closer to the individual parts. A task may remain understandable by itself while the objective that made it worth doing becomes difficult to see. Several tasks may be completed correctly even after the assumption, feature, or larger purpose they were meant to serve has changed.

The work becomes more precise locally while its purpose becomes less visible globally.

3. What continuity would make possible

As work becomes divided, its meaning is distributed across many places. A project contains tasks; a specification carries traces of research and discussion; a decision rests on assumptions that may no longer be visible. The practical promise of work-context infrastructure is modest: to let a person recover those relationships when they matter.

Instead of treating each document, task, or artifact as an isolated object, the system would help it remain part of a larger and revisable story.

FROM A PROJECT	see which tasks, attempts, and results gradually composed it.
FROM A SPECIFICATION	recover the research, questions, and interpretations that refined what it came to say.
FROM A DECISION	understand the assumptions, alternatives, evidence, and authority behind it.
FROM AN ARTIFACT	trace the work that produced it and the objective it was meant to advance.
FROM AN OBJECTIVE	follow the work outward and notice what remains incomplete, uncertain, or no longer aligned.

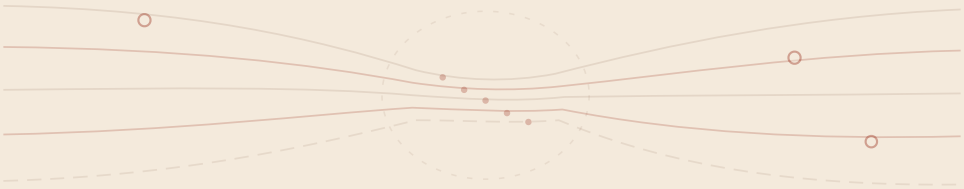
> The aim is not to produce a perfect account of work. It is to make forgetting less automatic: to preserve enough continuity that people can revisit why something exists, how it changed, and whether it still belongs to the purpose that first gave it meaning.

CONNECTED
Work can point beyond itself toward the contexts that explain it.

ATTRIBUTABLE
Ideas, judgments, and actions retain a visible source.

REVISABLE
Later learning can change earlier understanding without erasing its history.

HONEST ABOUT GAPS
Missing or conflicting context remains visible rather than being guessed.



4. Properties of recoverable continuity

No component diagram is required to state what this infrastructure must make possible. Its shape may vary. What matters is whether work can still be followed across decomposition, action, change, and uncertainty.

The properties below constrain any future arrangement. They do not describe a finished architecture or promise a complete account.

CONNECTED
Work can point to the contexts that explain it, including purpose, constraints, decisions, dependencies, and evidence.

ATTRIBUTABLE
Claims, judgments, decisions, and actions retain a visible source without mediation quietly changing who contributed what.

REVISABLE
Later learning can change current understanding while prior states and the reasons for change remain recoverable.

PLURAL
The same work can participate in several context paths without being forced into one hierarchy or one exclusive explanation.

TRAVERSABLE
A person can move from local work back toward its purpose and forward toward attempts, consequences, and assessed evidence.

HONEST ABOUT GAPS
Missing, conflicting, uncertain, and superseded relationships remain visible rather than being guessed or silently repaired.

PURPOSE why the work mattered > **ROUTE** the direction proposed > **WORK** what was bounded and attempted > **EVIDENCE** what the result supports > **REVISION** what changed afterward

> These properties do not make work self-explanatory. They make it possible to revisit what was known, what was decided, what changed, and what still cannot be justified.